

TWILIGHT OF THE TOPICAL IDOLS: KRITIK-ING IN THE AGE OF IMPERIALISM

William Shanahan¹

For the history of Western thinking in the past eight centuries has been one of replacement of ideas within a framework that has remained basically unchanged for nearly two millennia. Challenging this framework of interpretation means a rearrangement of our manner of perceiving the world, and it involves a reexamination of the body of human knowledge and its structural reconstruction into a new format. . . . Example after example could be cited, each testifying to the devastating effect of a general attitude toward the world that underlies the Western approach to knowledge. The basis of this attitude is the assumption that the world operates in certain predetermined ways, that it operates continuously under certain natural laws, and that the nature of every species is homogenous, with few real deviations. . . . Religious concepts, which have since been transformed into scientific and political beliefs, remain objects of beliefs as securely as if they had never been severed from their theological moorings. (Deloria, 1999, pp. 101-103)

For the history of debate thinking in the past eight decades has been one of replacement of ideas within a framework that has remained basically unchanged, except perhaps for the last decade and a half. The recent rash of reactionary, exclusionary violence (launched from perspectives believed as securely as if they had never been severed from

¹ The author is considered a white male in a society and an activity that privileges both white and male. This essay is written, in part, as an exercise in confronting its own settler colonialist privilege. Debate and dominant society particularly privileges its author for his credentials and his university status. As a community of concerned students and teachers, we must *do something* about and with our privilege. This essay is the author's attempt to act ethically in a brutally violent world.

their theological moorings) helps explain the consequent venom that certain debaters, judges, coaches, and programs discursively spew forth, often indiscriminately, inside and out of debate rounds. For the history of religious certainty over the past millennia is littered with example after example of the devastating effects of such securely held beliefs. The obvious retort is quick and correct: An equal amount of venom and violence has emanated from the “other” camps. Righteousness in the age of post-modernity no longer resides exclusively with certainty, but is found with equal vengeance among those who make no such claims to certainty and are equally certain that no one else should either. Shared responsibility is an excellent first step down a path toward *rapprochement*, though not without continued *perestroika*.

Challenging this framework of violently exclusionary interpretation means a re-arrangement of our manner of perceiving the debate-worlds. For an activity apparently so deeply imbedded in a nihilistic episteme (that is, where everything, *supposedly*, is debatable and little, if anything, is out-of-bounds), debate enforces a lot of *a priori* argumentative parameters and reveals itself to be at odds with its own tolerant, pluralistic self-image. *Who* would argue that our debate-worlds do not emerge from a series of basic practices that raise enormous access barriers, produce insular and, at times, idiosyncratic knowledge, and operate from a given, homogenous reality? *Many would*, naturally, and that is the *raison d’etre* for this essay: Challenging the dominant framework of interpretation known as traditional policymaking involves a reexamination of the body of debate knowledge and its structural reconstruction into a new format, a process fortunately ongoing for fifteen years or so and, unfortunately, increasingly being translated into the same dominant, vernacular it originally was intended to criticize.

The extraordinary occasion for writing this essay is the continuing controversy surrounding kritiks. That this remains a controversy is astounding. To consider debate without kritiks, at this time, is like considering a policy alternative by *wishing* away the status quo. Kritiks are a part of contemporary “policy” debate. The only real remaining

questions concern form, broadly conceived.¹ No amount of *fiat* or rule-making can disentangle contemporary debate practice from the many, disparate and powerful ways that alternative forms of debating have insinuated themselves into the everyday practice of debating. Traditional debate has not simply included these alternative practices into its largely unchanged structures, but has been fundamentally altered by its own engagement with radical challenges to most of its presumptive reality. The genuine controversy concerns what of traditional policymaking can survive.

The tradition of policy debating is incredibly rich and will emerge from this much needed revolution stronger and better. Kritiks must be considered in their context, as all good theory must. By the late eighties, NDT debate practice was beginning to push its policy vernacular to its extreme limits. For example, transforming a somewhat naïve brand of evaluating policy into a phenomenal engagement with the policy literature, a particular brand of literature to be sure, policy debate extended the (dis)advantage scenario to the far reaches of hypothetical cost-benefit analysis. These vast research skills translated into a ferocious *technē*, one which combined the dazzling speed and word economy from earlier generations with a level of unparalleled argumentative sophistication. In the transition however, strategy had become mundane and repetitive. Debates had begun to resemble its flows, practically inverting their representational relationship.² Any deviance was quickly

¹ The very dichotomy between form and content is one of the assumptive divisions regularly contested by argumentative approaches that refuse to accept the dominant forms of knowledge production in debate. Here, “form” is suggestive of the various, different ways that kritiks find their way into debates.

² Specifically, flows have long resembled a terrifying Civil War re-enactment, where armies (or arguments) are lined up against one another, thrown into battle, and those left standing (extended) are sized up, with winners declared. The battlefield carnage might seem too distant and inappropriate to desecrate in analogy. The violence “out there” is also ordered in the realities of this essay and of debate rounds. Jayan Nayar argues for the absolute importance of struggling against dominant, violent order-ings in all of our realities. Cf. “‘We’ are participants in ordered worlds, not merely observers. The choice whether we wish to recognize our own locations of ordered violence and participate in the struggle to resist their orderings, or whether we wish merely to observe violence in far-off worlds in order that our interventionary participation “out there” never destabilizes the ground upon which we stand. I suggest that we betray the spirit of transformatory struggle, despite of our

met with some accommodational or exclusionary measure. One quick historical example should suffice, though anyone familiar with contemporary policy debate could provide many more. The permutation emerged as a direct response to so-called “utopian” counter-plans, as a means to absorb the latter’s radical criticism of the “United States Federal Government.” Obviously, debaters and judges were the ones to actually enact this change and they did so zealously since it was they who were arguing *against* said utopian alternatives. Contrary to popular folklore, policy debate is flourishing.

Make no mistake about it. Debate is in the midst of a yet-to-be-determined *revolutionary* transformation, some of the outlines of which are visible and whose edifices have begun to be erected. Nonetheless, the powerful accommodational forces at work in debate, well-honed from years of *brilliant*, lived circumvention, are engaged in an extensive project of rehabilitation and reconstruction, designed to re-articulate the besieged, discursive hegemony of that *once-great*, tradition of policymaking. Contestatory, agonistic theoretical engagement exemplifies what is grand and worthy in our debate community. Provisional, local theory, imbedded in a specific resolutorial context and emerging from the particularities of individual debate rounds, expands knowledge and forms better praxis.¹ The long-dominant forms of traditional policymaking survived due to an extraordinary ability to *absorb* arguments and practices that threaten it, while maintaining an almost fetishized insularity. In the words of critical debate’s new demigod, the debate revolution needed to “strike twice,” at both the content and style of traditional debate, or risk the fate of the first Russian revolution, the sixties counter-revolution, and the worlds too numerous to mention assimilated by the Borg.²

expressions of support and even actions of professional expertise, if our own locations, within which are ordered and from which we ourselves order, remain unscrutinized” (p. 628).

¹ The author confesses one of his many biases: Raised in the era of heavy conditionality and so-called “utopian” counter-plans that required immediate, strong critical thinking skills to survive competitively, this author often prefers the thinking and arguing, which take place *in the room*, to the often machine-like preparation before the round (despite all appearances to the contrary).

² Please, forgive the pop cultural reference, but when alluding to the great cultural critic (and greatly diminished debate revolutionary), Slavoj Žižek, the urge to wax cultural is almost irresistible.

The second generation of kritiks and kritik-ing radically reconfigured debate practice and prepared the way for a plethora of alternative approaches to the topic, theory, technique, and especially to the role of judges and their decision-making. Basically, these second-generation approaches turned the early critical impulses, which originally were aimed mostly at our own debate arguments, toward the debate activity itself. The resulting changes were explosive, affecting almost every element of long-habituated and largely unchallenged debate practices. The ferocity with which the first-generation critical arguments and arguers attacked the traditional policy citadel was matched by the sheer diversity and divergence that the second wave deployed in their everyday debating, judging, and coaching. Rather than amassing a full-frontal assault on the citadel and being met with even greater reactionary force and retrenchment, transversal struggles instead tactically dispersed their resistances throughout the debate community and across rounds and tournaments, altering the very coordinates of debate's lived realities.¹ Seemingly suddenly (but actually with great work and perseverance against emboldened, albeit increasingly intermittent, reactionary argumentative force), the possibilities available in a given debate round burgeoned beyond any expectation, helping to open, especially affirmative, debate spaces apropos of a more diverse and varied politics, ideology, perspectives, and the like, which had been a part of debate for a long time and often was ill-served by the dominant, majority practices.

This critical second generation should have dissolved the distinction between kritiks and traditional policymaking, and our community recognized the compelling importance such a vital turn along debate's dominant pathways. Instead, a second wave of reactionary response has been emboldened by the competitive successes of several high profile teams and programs. This second wave lacks the nuance of even the most pedestrian, early responses that called out kritiks for performing in the "wrong forum" or for bringing the wrong "equipment" to a so-called sporting event. The former followed its irresistible

¹ See Bleiker (1997) and his introduction to the special edition on "Poetical World Politics," *Alternatives*, vol. 25, no. 3 (2000). Also, in an obvious nod to *debate's* new best friend, Slavoj Žižek,

sovereign logic and abandons to an argumentative outside any challenges to its authority.¹ The latter response sadly repeats the endless debate fantasy that it is a sport and that its “players” therefore are a part of their respective collegiate sports team complexes. Most glaringly, this new, old wave of reactionary debate politics must come to grips with forever changed nature of policy debating or forever be discarded in the dustbin of its own activity, an activity that otherwise still would have plenty of room for it.

The second critical generation exposed violent forms of domination throughout debate practice, including, at times insurmountable, access barriers for those whose tastes ran less to insular, idiosyncratic policymaking. Brutalizing forms of technique – that is, outrageous levels of speed in concert with impressive word economy that conspired to leave even the most engaged participants desperate for more than a few scribbles with a date, near-slavish devotion to the afore-mentioned minutiae of flowing where ink passes for argument and a drop is as good as a “kill,” and inevitable, speech *reconstruction* by debaters during cross-ex and prep time, and by judges during extended decision-time after debates – were a lightening rod of critical attention and served to help reduce those access barriers for a whole host of alternative, different perspectives to enter debate, now with concomitant opportunities to succeed. Evidence, long the cherished fundament of debaters and judges alike, came under sustained consideration and criticism for too frequently replacing actual argument by debaters and for far too frequently replacing actual arguments on judges’ flows, forcing reconstruction primarily around evidence and not the rest of debaters’ arguments. One of the strong beneficiaries of this second generation was the continued development and extension of first-generation kritiks real strength, that of opening up the decision-space to debating. Originally, the first generation, as mentioned earlier, focused on the arguments themselves. Later, the judges’ spaces were available to the debaters to activate, reshape, and transform into a plethora of definitively altered roles. Debaters were able to exploit the second generation’s reflexivity and to expose the inadequate, under theorized place for

see Lenin (2002, pp. 1-12).

¹ See “three theses” in Agamben (1998).

judges in their already-altered debate spaces; bringing judges' decision in line with the ongoing changes all around them. None of the changes mentioned in this paragraph, though, compare to those wrought by debaters' transformed relationship to the topical resolved-colon.

Due to editorial constraints, this essay limits itself to drawing a narrow strand out of and across contemporary debate theory and practice, in order to illustrate and lay to rest the "controversy." The strategy on which second-generation kritik-ing pivoted was exposing *interpretation* at the heart of topicality. While of course much energy over the decades has been poured into interpreting the topic, most of that energy was spent on ways of effectively limiting the topic by delimiting the boundaries around it and creating itself through a constitutive outside. Little effort was devoted previously to examining the *relationship* involved in affirming the topic. The activity of affirmation was engaged unproblematically because the realities imbedded in it were so long habituated. Topical relationships are, by no means, the extent and limit of this critical movement. Nonetheless, tracing the contours of how this relationship changed so dramatically over the last seven or eight years should help us to better understand why debate desperately needed kritiks and how kritik-ing so handily became such an integral, inseparable part of debate.

Most importantly perhaps, debate's invigorated reflexivity¹ finally acknowledged that the process of interpretation was neither neutral nor innocent. For far too long however, debate had proceeded as if affirmatives' relationship to the topic was unproblematic and did not require examination. This is not to say that our very erudite community failed to recognize how interpretation was "subjective," but rather they failed to accept the very notion that subjectivity itself was tied to politics, ideology, and philosophical bent. Not surprisingly, debate's insularity fairly effectively prevented five decades of sustained criticism against the canons of Western philosophy and politics from entering into debate rounds and debate thinking, as if most of, for example, Continental philosophy had nothing

to offer us. Even the most casual glance across a variety of disciplines demonstrated the irrefutable relevance of so-called post-structuralism and postmodernism to debate practice. For an activity that prides itself on its erudition, these theoretical oversights were conspicuous and disabling. How could such a sophisticated argumentative community *fail* to consider and evaluate the relevance of such far-reaching and important changes in academic scholarship?

One important theoretical consideration emerged from the discernment of a previously unnoticed topical function (that the topic might be considered to have particular functions at all was itself the result of the gradual influx of discourse theory). Every year and before every debate, the resolved-colon hails or interpellates debaters as affirmative subjects. Lacanian Marxist Louis Althusser, while discussing the mirror-structure of bourgeois capitalist ideology, argues that it ensures “the interpellation of ‘individuals’ as subjects” and their mutual recognition of each other and themselves.² For debate, the topic *hails* affirmative debaters and their *lac*’s answer that hail, either explicitly or implicitly. Too often, debaters presume that if they do not debate something then it does not matter. The second generation exposed this sentiment as fallacious and sought to argumentatively contradict it in debate rounds. An unacknowledged topical hail no less hails affirmative debaters. The implications are obvious and legion: Whether or not debaters accept the topical hail, they still are interpellated by it and can be defeated by it, if their opponents respond more effectively to it. The topic’s relationship to everyone in the debate was exposed and debatable.

Once exposed and debated, the topical hail further delineated the various functions of the topic. This lesson was driven home to the Fort Hays State debate squad during its visit

¹ The author uses “*invigorated* reflexivity” because, of course, debate always has brought a measure of self-examination through the everyday practice of debating and, especially, through debaters’ ability to debate the rules of the day, *during* the game.

² Louis Althusser, “Ideology and Ideological State Apparatuses (Notes toward an Investigation),” in *Lenin and Philosophy*, trans. Ben Brewster (London: Monthly Review Press) 180-181. Pointedly and especially relevant for this essay’s examination of traditional policymaking, Althusser also suggests

to a California museum devoted to the indigenous peoples of this continent. The self-identified indigenous docent asked why our group wanted to tour the museum and attached library. When we explained that we were a group of university students and teacher debating a topic about Indian Country, his excitement and curiosity grew. We carefully explained how we refused to support the literal topical meaning, calling for *increased* Federal control throughout Indian Country. He was visibly upset. So, we again took great care to explain how we finessed our relationship to the topic by avoiding following it to the letter. He was unimpressed by our semantic games, gave us our receipt, and summarily dismissed us. At different times during our visit, he would walk by us and variously express his discontent with our project. For instance, he queried loudly “how our efforts to destroy his people” was going. Only after extensive de-briefing was the docent willing to concede that we, in fact, did not support the ongoing genocide of the indigenous peoples of Turtle Island. The harsh, embarrassing lessons learned during that visit extracted a painful psychic cost and are continuing to affect Fort Hays State debate today. The debate topic interpellated us as active participants in cultural annihilation, rather than simply members of an occupying force whose colonialist privilege derives from that annihilation (a slight difference, indeed, but one we were loathe to relinquish).

Affirmative debaters’ relationship to the topic constituted them in particular, often undesirable ways. The topic was not simply some bounded space or a container from which to draw topical plans. Instead, the topic established a relationship through interpellation that inhered irrespective of what the particular political affinities of the debaters were. The relationship was both political and ethical, and needed to be debated as such. When we blithely call for United States Federal Government policymaking, we are not *immune* to the colonialist legacy that establishes our place on this continent. We cannot wish away the horrific atrocities perpetrated *everyday* in our name simply by refusing to acknowledge these implications. That body in Washington, D.C. can no longer be isolated from brutal acts

that so long as subjects “recognize what they are and behave accordingly, everything will be all right: Amen—’*So be it.*’” A more perfect explanation of fiat has not been proffered.

employed to make policy. Importantly, the second generation again allowed examination of the ethical relationship inherent in affirming, or refusing to debate, the interpellated, often virulent violence involved in such affirmation.

One of the more startling argumentative revelations associated with the second generation was the ability to debate topicality according to the altered trajectories of this topical relationship. Specifically, topicality lost its aura as an invincibly *a priori* argument. This allowed debaters to approach the topic and topicality like all the other arguments in a debate round. Learning the lessons from the first generation's internal or immanent kritiks, debaters started to apply the logic of the (dis)advantage to topicality debates. Rather than taking the claims of potential abuse and the imputed justification for all that one's topical interpretation might engender, alternative topical approaches mitigated these links with responses previously reserved for the disad. The "race to the margin" was exposed for the sham it was. Excessively broad approaches justified by one's interpretations were handled with the charge of being not intrinsic to the interpretation, for example.

More devastating, though, were the brilliant uses of (parallel) impact turns designed to evaluate the consequences of *not* allowing an otherwise desirable affirmative approach to the topic. The daunting logic of cost benefit analysis was turned back on topicality debating to reveal the ethical and political costs associated with such narrow interpretive practices. Affirmative debaters refused to speak the unproblematic topical words of imperialist domination and, instead, cleared an ethically defensible place from which to launch their politically-charged rhetoric and arguments. The topical hail could be repudiated, so long as the "terminal impacts" of topicality arguments could be denied or mitigated. The regular refrain of preparation, ground division, and prior warning (most recently converted into the mantra of competitive equity) advanced unmasked and revealed the contented grin of colonialist excess. Rather than taking these impacts at face value, alternative affirmative debaters could provide sufficient warrants for debatability by demonstrating strategic funnels through which alternative approaches must flow and against which perceptive negatives could prepare. The ridiculous application of outmoded notions like the need for

switch-side debating were confronted with now-obvious response that the topic included many more sides than could be handled adequately by simply switching between only two.¹ The separation of affirmative cases from evaluations of topicality could not sustain itself once its superficial defense was examined outside of received debate dogma.

The result, as alluded to earlier, was a variety of different, debatable topical approaches supported by ethical consideration of the topic's interpellation and its attendant political baggage. Affirmative teams were not required to labor under the burdensome onus of U.S.-style imperialism. They brought to bear diverse and powerful interpretive tools that exposed the topic for what it was, ordinary language requiring defensible evaluative criteria whose reasons must be open to strategic and ethical scrutiny. The masters' houses need not be dismantled by only the masters' tools any longer. The ethical and political weight of defending one of the most voracious, genocidal machines in planetary history was lifted from affirmatives' shoulders. The resulting beautiful, ugly din of voices better reflected the increasing diversity of the debate community and the longstanding variety of alternative political ideologies. Debate did not require the colonialist stain of privilege to determine its courses and could respect and respond to these occasionally disrespectful theoretical rebuffs. If for no other reason than this affirmative implosion, kritiks have made debate over into a more ethical, politically acceptable activity.

This brief excursus into kritik-ing topicality certainly is not exhaustive of debate's critical turn and is intended instead to illustrate the invaluable contributions kritiks have made and are continuing to make to our community. Neither petulant tantrums nor sustained diatribes can force these alternative approaches out of debate because they have fundamentally altered the coordinates of debate's reality. This critical implosion, as reminiscent of as it is obligated to Friedrich Nietzsche's philosophical dynamite, has blasted a theoretical vacuum in debate that regularly is filled by the intelligent, ethically committed arguments and voices of these previously excluded debaters (Zupančič, 2003). Debate is

¹ More recently, the demand for switch-side debating is best handled by calling for its practitioners to follow what they preach, switch sides themselves, and actually debate kritiks.

beginning to realize its political obligations to no longer unproblematically affirm the stupefying violence that defines this nation's grand history and contemporary affairs of state. Debate begrudgingly, but inescapably, is acknowledging the enormous debt owed due to its privileged position in a privileged society. Kritiks, like Nietzsche's philosophy, might be easy to find, but they are equally difficult to lose. Debate's idols let loose with the hollow sounds of their inflated bowels when hammered by critical tuning forks (Nietzsche, 1968). Before an intolerable political stench is released, debate and debaters must lose their reactionary, violent bent and face up to the unavoidable conclusion: Kritiks and kritik-ing are here for good (and evil).

References

- Agamben, G. (1998). *Homo sacer: Sovereign power and bare life* (D. Heller-Raozen, Trans.). Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press.
- Bleiker, R. (1997). Forget IR theory. *Alternatives*, 22, 56-86.
- Deloria, V. (1999). *For this land: Writings on religion in America*. New York: Routledge.
- Lenin, V. I. (2002). *Revolution at the gates: A selection of writings from February to October 1917 by V. I. Lenin*. London: Verso.
- Nayar, J. (1999). Orders of inhumanity. *Transnational Law and Contemporary Problems*, 9, 599-628.
- Nietzsche, F. (1968). *The portable Nietzsche* (W. Kaufmann, Trans.). New York: Viking.
- Zupančič, A. (2003). *The shortest shadow: Nietzsche's philosophy of the two*. Cambridge: MIT Press.

Copyright of Contemporary Argumentation & Debate is the property of Contemporary Argumentation & Debate and its content may not be copied or emailed to multiple sites or posted to a listserv without the copyright holder's express written permission. However, users may print, download, or email articles for individual use.